

Understanding the Jesse Challenge

Leadership Identity, Organizational Leverage, and the Next Phase of NexGen

Purpose

The purpose of this document is not to criticize Jesse.

The purpose is to accurately diagnose what we are observing as a leadership team so we can determine the best path forward.

Many of the challenges we have discussed over the past several months initially appeared to be communication problems. As we continued reflecting, a more nuanced picture began to emerge.

This document summarizes those observations and identifies what may be the next phase of development for both the leadership team and NexGen as a company.

The First Realization

For a long time, it was easy to assume that if Jesse simply understood what we were trying to accomplish, he would naturally become more supportive of the process.

The evidence suggests the issue may be more complex than that.

We have spent years discussing:

- Prioritization
- Planning
- Initiative ownership
- Execution
- Organizational alignment
- Strategic thinking
- Leadership development

While there has been progress, many of the same patterns continue to appear.

This suggests we may be treating a capability difference, operating-style difference, or identity transition as a communication problem.

Key Insight

A communication problem is solved by better explanation.

A capability or operating-style difference is solved through role design, accountability, and systems.

What We Initially Thought

At first, it appeared that Jesse simply did not understand the value of leadership alignment, strategic thinking, organizational development, and the invisible work required to influence organizational outcomes.

Over time, a different picture emerged.

When pressed on specifics, Jesse often identifies many of the same problems that the rest of the leadership team identifies:

- Lack of collaboration
- Poor communication
- Teams working independently
- Slow execution
- Misalignment

The issue is not that he cannot see the problems.

The issue is that he often does not connect those problems to the systems being built to solve them.

Key Insight

Jesse sees the symptoms.

He does not always believe in the treatment.

The Invisible Work Challenge

One of the most important discoveries from this discussion is that the issue is not recognition.

Andrew is not seeking praise for the work he does.

The concern is whether the leverage created by leadership work is fully understood.

Examples include:

- Building alignment
- Improving communication
- Calling out passive agreement
- Establishing accountability
- Creating systems
- Improving decision quality
- Shaping organizational behavior
- Developing leadership capability

These activities often have delayed and invisible benefits.

By contrast, Jesse naturally gravitates toward visible work:

- Sales
- Customer relationships
- Vendor relationships
- Business development
- Revenue generation
- External conversations

Both create value.

One is simply easier to see.

Key Insight

You don't need Jesse to value the work.

You need him to respect the outcomes it produces.

The Opportunity vs. Outcome Problem

One of the most important observations from this discussion is the distinction between opportunities and outcomes.

Jesse frequently identifies worthwhile opportunities.

Examples include:

- Pavers
- Vendor relationships
- Marketing concepts
- Strategic partnerships

- New service offerings

The problem is not the opportunities themselves.

The problem is that value creation often stops too early in the process.

Key Insight

Jesse creates opportunities.

The organization creates outcomes.

Those are not the same contribution.

Real Example: Pavers

Jesse identified pavers as an opportunity.

However, before the organization had alignment around:

- Sales process
- Pricing
- Marketing
- Contracts
- Service delivery
- Training
- Rollout strategy
- Ownership

the initiative was already moving toward implementation.

The concern is not whether pavers are a good idea.

The concern is whether introducing initiatives without a complete implementation path creates organizational drift.

Real Example: Vendor Negotiations

Jesse initiated a vendor pricing discussion.

However:

- Diana built the PowerPoint.
- Diana structured the meeting.

- Andrew drove much of the discussion.
- The execution burden shifted elsewhere.

The opportunity was identified.

The organizational work was completed by others.

Real Example: AI Generated Plans

A recurring pattern has emerged where Jesse uses AI to generate plans, then presents the output as though the initiative is largely ready to proceed.

The issue is not AI.

The issue is confusing artifact generation with organizational readiness.

AI can create:

- Plans
- Proposals
- Strategies
- Documents

in minutes.

However, AI cannot automatically solve:

- Alignment
- Prioritization
- Resource allocation
- Ownership
- Change management
- Adoption
- Execution

Key Insight

Generating an artifact is not the same as creating an outcome.

Why This Creates Friction

The friction is not caused by the ideas themselves.

The friction comes from the hidden cost attached to every new idea.

Every idea consumes:

- Leadership attention
- Discussion time
- Context switching
- Emotional energy
- Evaluation effort
- Potential drift from agreed priorities

This is especially important because the leadership team has already identified excessive work-in-progress as one of its primary constraints.

Key Insight

A good idea is not automatically a priority.

Leadership Identity May Be the Next Constraint

As we reflected on the evolution of the leadership team, another pattern emerged.

The last several months focused on:

- Alignment
- Trust
- Communication
- Accountability
- Healthy conflict

That work helped expose our next operational constraint around execution and prioritization.

However, it may have also exposed another challenge:

Leadership Identity

As organizations grow, leaders often need to evolve along with them.

The role that creates success in one stage of growth is not always the role that creates the most value in the next stage.

Andrew

Andrew appears to have increasingly found his identity in the CEO role.

His focus naturally gravitates toward:

- Leadership development
- Organizational alignment
- Strategic direction
- Culture
- Accountability
- Decision quality
- Influencing outcomes through people

Much of this work is highly leveraged but largely invisible.

Diana

Diana appears to have increasingly found her identity at the intersection of marketing, organizational effectiveness, communication, and execution.

Her focus naturally gravitates toward:

- Marketing strategy
- Sales enablement
- Customer experience
- Communication
- Coordination
- Planning
- Organizational clarity
- Adoption

She frequently serves as the bridge between ideas and implementation, translating concepts into plans that can actually be executed.

Because she experiences the downstream effects of misalignment firsthand, she places a high value on structure, prioritization, and execution discipline.

Drew

Drew appears to have increasingly found his identity as an operator.

His focus naturally gravitates toward:

- Execution
- Ownership
- Implementation
- Problem solving

- Driving initiatives to completion

His feedback repeatedly highlighted the need for fewer priorities, greater collaboration, and stronger collective execution.

Jesse

Jesse's future-state identity may still be evolving.

Historically, much of his value has been tied to:

- Sales
- Revenue generation
- Relationships
- Opportunity identification
- Business development
- Ownership

However, as the company grows, it is becoming increasingly important to define what his highest-leverage contribution looks like within the next version of NexGen.

This may be one of the most important unresolved questions facing the leadership team.

The Founder Transition Challenge

Another possibility worth considering is that this challenge reflects a common founder transition.

Many founders create value through:

- Relationships
- Opportunity recognition
- Hustle
- Fast decisions
- Pursuing opportunities wherever they appear

Those behaviors are often essential in the early stages of a company's growth.

The challenge is that growth changes the equation.

As organizations become larger and more complex, leadership value increasingly shifts toward:

- Prioritization
- Focus
- Resource allocation

- Organizational alignment
- Disciplined execution

This creates a natural tension because the behaviors that helped create the company are not always the same behaviors required to scale it.

Key Insight

The skills required to build a company are not always the same skills required to scale a company.

Or put another way:

What creates growth in Stage 1 can create drift in Stage 2.

This does not mean the founder is wrong.

It means the environment changed.

The challenge may not be that Jesse creates opportunities.

The challenge may be determining how opportunity creation fits into a leadership system that is increasingly focused on alignment, execution, and organizational leverage.

This is a transition many founders struggle with because it requires evolving from asking:

"Is this a good opportunity?"

to asking:

"Is this the best opportunity for us to pursue right now?"

The Most Important Realization

The objective should not be:

"Get Jesse to think like Andrew."

That is unlikely to succeed and may not even be desirable.

The objective should be:

Create a leadership system that allows each leader to contribute from their strengths while holding everyone to the same standards of prioritization, ownership, and accountability.

The system should protect the company from drift regardless of who introduces the idea.

Key Insight

The solution may not be changing Jesse.

The solution may be strengthening the system around idea evaluation, prioritization, ownership, and execution.

Possible Next Step

The next evolution of the leadership team may not be another process improvement.

It may be helping each leader answer a simple question:

"What is my highest-leverage contribution to the future version of NexGen?"

The answer will likely be different for each person.

However, greater clarity around that question may:

- Reduce tension
- Improve accountability
- Increase ownership
- Clarify expectations
- Improve collaboration
- Help each leader focus on where they create the most value

Most importantly, it may help ensure that every member of the leadership team is growing alongside the company rather than operating from a version of the company that no longer exists.

Key Insight

The next phase of leadership development may be less about improving communication and more about helping each leader discover, define, and fully own their future identity within NexGen.

Final Reflection

The leadership team recently identified two major constraints:

1. Aligned Execution

The organization needs to improve how it executes together by focusing on fewer initiatives, reducing drift, and increasing collaboration.

2. Leadership Identity

The leadership team may need to clarify what each leader's highest-leverage contribution looks like in the future version of NexGen.

These two challenges are connected.

The company is evolving.

The leadership team must evolve with it.

Final Insight

Ideas create possibilities.

Execution creates results.

Leadership exists to bridge the gap between the two.

And the next phase of NexGen may be helping each leader determine how they uniquely contribute to that bridge.